

On the Familiarity of Things: A Note on AI-Authored Documents

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Example

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Abstract

Documents authored by general-purpose language models tend to drift toward visual novelty: branded sans-serif body text, decorative gradients, emoji bullets, neon accent colors. This brief note argues that the appropriate default for ordinary documents is APA7, not because APA7 is exciting but because it is familiar — and familiarity, here, is a feature.

Introduction

The first time someone reads a document produced by a model, the typography itself is a signal. A reader who has spent decades reading APA7-formatted papers, business memos in Times New Roman, and reports with grayscale charts will register the unusual font, the colored heading, and the emoji bullet not as personality but as *wrongness*. The signal is louder than the content.

A simple default

Default to APA7. When the user explicitly asks for something else, pick that something else with care and ask what specifically they want different.

References

American Psychological Association. (2020). *Publication manual of the American Psychological Association* (7th ed.). <https://doi.org/10.1037/0000165-000>